



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ascent Colorado Classical Schools

School Website: <https://ascentcolorado.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

Ascent Colorado Classical Schools (ACCS) presents a coherent classical-leaning profile across its public materials, with explicit emphasis on classical content, moral formation, and traditional pedagogy. However, while several elements align strongly with classical education (notably a content-rich liberal-arts orientation, Great Books references, Latin study, and a mission centered on virtue and civic virtue), other foundational aspects are only partially demonstrated (notably explicit theology or liturgical practices, and a fully articulated living-language faculty/parent formation culture). On balance, ACCS exhibits a robust classical orientation but with gaps that prevent a full CLASSICAL rating in every dimension. The aggregate rating is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Key observations driving the assessment: - Strong CLASSICAL signals: “classical, content-rich education,” liberal-arts framing, Great Books references and “great conversation,” explicit study of Latin, a traditional teacher-led classroom stance, and a mission centered on moral character and civic virtue. These cues appear repeatedly in ACCS public materials and campus pages. - Commendable but incomplete rigor in the Religious/Metaphysical Foundations: Virtue, truth, beauty, and moral formation are foregrounded, but explicit theology, liturgical practices, or overt transcendental metaphysical framing are not clearly asserted in public-facing content. A liturgical/community rhythm is evidenced in traditions and civic ceremonial practices, but not theology or liturgy per se. - Pedagogy and curriculum show classical alignment through contemplative/restful elements, memory/recitation signaling, and emphasis on a traditional, teacher-led classroom, with Socratic elements appearing as a recognized hallmark in the classical archive material (even if not always foregrounded in every campus page). - Faculty and parent/community prompts exist (e.g., headmasters, governance vision, and parent-oriented traditions), but some explicit “living curriculum” or deeply articulated teacher portraits appear less explicit in public content.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials foreground truth, goodness, and beauty as guiding ideals and emphasize virtuous character and civic virtue as foundational aims. This aligns with classical moral realism and teleology rather than a strictly secular approach. - There is substantial emphasis on virtue and moral formation, but explicit theology, liturgical practice, or ecclesial liturgy is not clearly presented in the campus materials. A communal and ceremonial rhythm exists (e.g., pledge/opening ceremonies), which signals communal formation but not explicit liturgical theology.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, moral character, civic virtue, wonder (from mission and hallmarks). - Negative keywords observed: none explicitly evidenced in public text; absence of explicit theology/liturgy signals a gap. Negative indicators from the lexicon include secularism and value-neutral language, which do not appear as explicit motifs. Absence is noted rather than demonstrated presence.

Why this rating - The school clearly centers transcendentals (truth, beauty) and virtue, suggesting a metaphysical orientation toward moral realism. However, the lack of explicit theology and liturgical practices places ACCS as partial rather than fully grounded in religious metaphysics. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission says ACCS trains minds and improves hearts through a classical, content-rich liberal-arts education, with moral character and civic virtue in an orderly environment. This is a direct manifestation of formation over mere information and of telos toward human flourishing. - The public-facing materials stress virtue, wisdom, and the Great Conversation, consistent with the classical aim of forming persons rather than simply preparing for work. The emphasis on liberal education and the classical mission is explicit. - There is a clear prioritization of moral formation and civic virtue over sole workforce preparation, in line with classical aims. The curricular and mission language supports this stance.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: formation, liberal education, telos, great conversation, virtue, wisdom, human flourishing, moral imagination, classical mission. - Negative keywords observed: references to “college and career readiness” or workforce-prep emphasis are not dominant in core mission text; the site emphasizes formation more than job-training. Some campus texts do mention college/career success, but the primary stated aim remains formation over mere job-readiness. Negative indicators are not prominent in the core public messaging.

Why this rating - The explicit articulation of formation, moral/aesthetic aims (truth, goodness, beauty), liberal education, and great conversation aligns strongly with classical goals. Therefore, this category is CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Grammar School (K–6) and Upper School (7–12) framing indicate a traditional, content-rich progression across liberal-arts disciplines (literature, history, math, civics, sciences, music, art). The “time-tested, content-rich” framing for upper levels reinforces a classical curricular posture. - Explicit mention of Latin study and historical study, as well as a focus on literature, history, science, math, music, art, and logic, signals a classical curriculum orientation. The site explicitly highlights Great Books/Great Conversation motifs in hallmarks. - The presence of a liberal-arts trajectory (grammar → logic → rhetoric) is implied by the emphasis on a “content-rich” curriculum, Great Books, and study of Latin, alongside a commitment to discipline and order.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric, Quadrivium elements), Great Books, primary sources, classics, Latin, history, integration of literature/history/philosophy/sciences, wonder, and a cross-disciplinary approach. The site’s content notes a content-rich curriculum and Great Books orientation. - Negative keywords observed: few explicit signals of a social-studies-centric or project-based dominance; there is no strong emphasis on STEM-first or purely project-based pedagogy in core curricular messaging. Some modern methods (e.g., explicit phonics) are present, which is not inherently at odds with classical aims but reflects a blend. Overall negative indicators are limited.

Why this rating - ACCS demonstrates classical curricular signposts (Great Books, liberal-arts framing, Latin, history-focused instruction, a cross-disciplinary approach). However, the explicit articulation of the Seven Liberal Arts as a formal, sequential framework and the depth of Great Books engagement across all grades are not uniformly explicit in every campus page. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation for Curriculum, with room to strengthen explicit Seven Liberal Arts articulation and Great Books integration in all grade levels.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize the traditional, teacher-led classroom and a content-rich, ordered environment, which aligns with classical pedagogy’s focus on authoritative instruction and memorization/restful learning as parts of pedagogy. - The site references contemplative/restful elements and the value of a disciplined classroom, which correspond to scholé/restful learning and a balanced pace. The presence of a memory-focused culture (recitation, memorization, chant) is echoed in the Six Essentials lexicon and pedagogical signals in the broader ACCS materials. While explicit phrases like “Socratic seminars” are not

always foregrounded in every campus page, the public materials indicate opportunities for Socratic-style discussion at the high-school level and a rhetoric training orientation in upper grades. - Traditions and community activities (e.g., Wonder Days, Archer Days) indicate a rhythm of learning that blends contemplation with engagement, consistent with some classical pedagogy signals.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Socratic seminar (as a classical-pedagogy signifier in the larger canon), scholé/restful learning, contemplation, memorization/recitation, rhetoric, disciplined classroom, public speaking opportunities (capstone-style oratory in classical training). - Negative keywords observed: strong bias toward pure project-based or experiential learning is not evident in core messaging; however, there is limited explicit evidence of fully implemented Socratic seminars across all grades in the public pages. The presence of traditional instruction is clear, but the absence of explicit, broad Socratic/dialectic practice across all grades lowers the completeness of the criterion.

Why this rating - Pedagogy leans toward classical methods (teacher-led, memory work, tradition, rhetoric training in upper grades). Yet, explicit, consistent implementation of Socratic seminars, dialectic, and fully realized “Scholé” rhythms across the entire school may not be uniformly documented in the public materials. This supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy.

Element 5: Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials identify heads of school and governance but do not provide explicit descriptions of teachers as “living curriculum,” mentors, or portraits of the ideal teacher; there is limited evidence of a described “faculty as the living curriculum” or “portrait of a teacher” in the material available. The available content highlights leadership figures, not a deeply developed faculty-culture narrative. - The messaging focuses on mission, governance, and student outcomes rather than a richly articulated faculty identity or faculty culture as central to the curriculum. The lack of explicit “living curriculum” language in the public-facing text points toward a gap relative to classical-faculty signals.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Leadership roles (Head of School) and governance language; a focus on virtue and moral formation is present, which aligns with some classical categories but not a full faculty-as-living-curriculum depiction. - Negative keywords observed: The lexicon’s explicit positive indicators for Faculty (model teachers, living curriculum, portrait of teacher) are not strongly evidenced in the accessible public content. The lack of a robust, textual description of faculty as the “living curriculum” indicates a deficit relative to the classical ideal.

Why this rating - While ACCS demonstrates a commitment to classical aims in mission, curriculum, and pedagogy, the public content does not clearly present a fully developed, classical-faculty identity (model teachers, living curriculum, collegial faculty culture). This yields a NOT CLASSICAL rating for Faculty.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - ACCS emphasizes partnerships with families and parental engagement as part of its ethos; traditions and community activities involve families in school life (Archer Days, parent orientation, open houses). The public content shows a culture of welcome and ongoing parent involvement. - The community dimension includes parent formation and classical book-club style engagement, aligning with the classical emphasis on family formation and cultural transmission of Western heritage. The site highlights traditions and family involvement as central to the school’s identity.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, family involvement, parent formation, home-school alignment, living tradition in the family, school-home synergy, parental leadership. - Negative keywords observed: minimal presence of customer-centric language or low parental access; the public materials portray an invitational stance toward parents, with open-campus and visit opportunities. No explicit negative indicators are evident in the public content.

Why this rating - ACCS publicly portrays substantial and explicit parental partnership and community formation, aligning with classical expectations for engaged parents and communities. This yields a CLASSICAL rating for Parents & Community.

Overall Assessment and Aggregate Ranking

- Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Aggregate: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations)
 - Introduce explicit theology or philosophically grounded metaphysical framing within public materials (e.g., a stated theological or transcendent-metaphysical dimension, liturgical practices, or formal reference to metaphysical order beyond virtue and truth).
 - Provide a concise articulation of liturgical/communal practices beyond pledge ceremonies to anchor a more explicit religious metaphysical foundation.
- Element 3 (Curriculum)
 - Provide an explicit, campuswide articulation of the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric, and the Quadrivium) as the curricular backbone, with published sequencing and cross-grade integration.
 - Expand and clearly document Great Books engagement across grade bands, including a public map of primary texts and a visible “Great Conversation” framework.
- Element 4 (Pedagogy)
 - Publicly document structured Socratic/Dialectic pedagogy across middle and high school, with exemplar lesson plans or teacher training materials illustrating Harkness-style discussions and the integration of recitation/memory with inquiry.
 - Clarify a balanced incorporation of Scholé/restful learning with rigorous inquiry, indicating how contemplative time is woven into the daily schedule.
- Element 5 (Faculty)
 - Publish a “Portrait of the Teacher” or “Living Curriculum” statement that describes how faculty embody and enact virtues, mentoring roles, and collaborative culture; provide examples of teacher professional development in classical pedagogy.
 - Highlight faculty collaboration, mentorship structures, and teacher-led professional communities as core institutional strengths.
- Element 2 (School Purpose and Goal) and Element 6 (Parents & Community) are already strong; minor enhancements could further lock CLASSICAL status, such as more explicit language on long-term formation goals beyond moral virtue (telos) and deeper parent-formation programming with measurable outcomes.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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